

ASO + screenshots

Week 8 Lecture 2 · B2C to \$10k MRR

Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Title, subtitle, keywords: ranking weight and what the stores actually index
- The first-three rule for screenshots: what converts, what does not
- Featuring: what indie apps can realistically control
- Localization as the highest-leverage ASO action for small teams
- Apple Search Ads basics on a \$5-50/day budget

The title-subtitle-keyword system

App name carries the most ranking weight

- The app name (title) has the highest keyword ranking weight in both stores
- App Store: 30-character limit for the name field
- Google Play: 30 characters for the title, 80 for the short description
- Formula that works: BrandName: Primary Keyword
 - Example: Streaks: Habit Tracker (not Streaks)
- Source: AppFollow ASO Title Playbook (2026); RevenueCat ASO guide (2022)

Subtitle and keywords: the second and third layers

- App Store subtitle: 30 characters, indexed by the algorithm, shown under the title in search
- Keywords field: 100 characters, comma-separated, not visible to users
- Do not repeat words already in the title or subtitle — the algorithm ignores duplicates
- Google Play: the short description (80 chars) and full description are both indexed; there is no separate keyword field

Keyword strategy: avoid where giants bid

- Apple Search Ads reveals keyword search popularity scores (0-100)
- Target scores 20-55: real search volume, but major companies do not dominate
- Scores below 20: too niche, not enough volume to matter
- Scores above 55: you are competing with Duolingo, Headspace, and Calm
- Source: TrySonar Apple Search Ads guide (2026) — "70% of App Store visitors use search to find apps"

Screenshots that convert

The first-three rule

- On iPhone in portrait search results, only 3 screenshots are visible before the user must tap "See all"
- Those three screenshots do the same job as a landing page hero section
- Frames 1-3 must convey: what the app does, for whom, and why it is better
- Source: AppFollow ASO Title Playbook (2026) — the first-three rule explained with competitive analysis methodology

Benefit framing vs feature labels

Feature label (weak)

Benefit framing (strong)

- "Dark mode support"
 - "Multi-language"
 - "Offline mode"
 - "Push notifications"
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- "Works the way your eyes do at 11pm"
 - "Read in your language"
 - "Works on the plane, no WiFi needed"
 - "Never miss the moment to practice"

Screenshot hierarchy for a subscription app

1. **Hero:** one core promise, your best visual, benefit caption
2. **Aha moment:** show the moment the user gets the value they paid for
3. **Social proof or stats:** user count, rating, or a one-line review
4. Frames 4-10: feature details for users who are already interested
 - Rule: if you remove the caption, the screenshot should still communicate something

Featuring and localization

What indie apps can actually control for featuring

- Apple features apps that use new platform APIs (WidgetKit, Live Activities, SharePlay) in the release they ship
- Google Play features well-designed apps that follow Material You guidelines
- Tony Dinh (BlackMagic, Wins, XWord) pattern: ship the new API feature fast, email the editorial team with a story about the app
- What you cannot control: whether the editorial team picks your app
- What you can control: the quality of the listing they review when they do

Localization: the highest-leverage ASO action

- A single new language unlocks a new search index entirely
- Title, subtitle, and keywords are localized separately — you can optimize per market
- Start with one market where your app already has organic installs
- A localized title with local keywords outperforms an English title even in non-English markets where users are bilingual
- Source: RevenueCat ASO guide (2022) — localization section

Apple Search Ads for indie budgets

ASA campaign structure for a solo founder

- **Brand campaign:** your own app name as an exact-match keyword — protect it, costs almost nothing
- **Competitor campaign:** exact-match on direct competitor names (expensive, use carefully)
- **Discovery campaign:** search match turned on, let Apple find new keywords, harvest what converts
- Source: TrySonar Apple Search Ads guide (2026)

The \$5-50/day framework

- Days 1-7: \$5/day discovery campaign. Let the algorithm show your ad for broad relevant terms.
- Review the search terms report. Promote high-CPI/high-converting terms to exact match. Negative-match irrelevant terms.
- Weeks 2-4: raise to \$20-50/day on exact-match campaigns for your top 5 keywords.
- After 4-6 weeks: pause. Measure organic keyword rank lift. The ASA spend builds organic momentum.
- Source: TrySonar Apple Search Ads guide (2026) — the cyclical strategy

Measuring ASA: CPI vs revenue per install

- Vanity metric: installs from ads
- Actionable metric: revenue per install (RPI) for the ASA cohort vs organic cohort
- If ASA CPI is \$2.00 and your trial-to-paid rate is 10% and your price is \$29.99/year: $RPI = \$3.00$. Profitable.
- If trial-to-paid is 2%: $RPI = \$0.60$. Not profitable. Fix the paywall before scaling ASA.
- Source: TrySonar Apple Search Ads guide (2026); RevenueCat State of Subscription Apps 2025 (trial-to-paid benchmarks)

Take-aways

1. The app name carries the most ranking weight: spend your 30 characters on brand + primary keyword.
2. The first three screenshots function as a landing page hero — write benefit captions, not feature labels.
3. Featuring is not a strategy; it is a reward for good execution on new platform APIs.
4. Localization is the highest ASO leverage available to a one-person team.
5. ASA works best when your paywall converts — validate conversion before scaling ad spend.

"70% of App Store visitors use search to find apps."

Peter, TrySonar Apple Search Ads Guide (2026)

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Ship your build. Rewrite your title. Replace three screenshots. Non-negotiable.
- **Thursday:** Submit to your chosen store. Start the capstone scaffold (funnel + problem + interventions).
- **Friday:** Capstone scaffold session (60 min). Five prompts in the reading.
- **Week 9:** Lifecycle messaging and referral loops — the next growth layer after distribution.